

Ava Pace

My Key Insight Within my Barcelona Classroom

At the end of my sophomore year here at the University of South Carolina, I took the opportunity to go abroad for one month through the 'Beyond The Classroom' study abroad program. One of the two classes was fully based around making a huge project working with a group determined at the start of the program. The project could be any form of creative medium that would focus on either a piece of culture found in Barcelona, or about the trip and the overall experience itself. My group decided we wanted our project to promote the trip and show others a glimpse into our experience.

Our group ended up being made up of four students who had wildly different ideas and expectations when it came to what we were going to make of this project. While we all had different majors, they were all a part of the School of Journalism and Mass Communications, but each of us wanted to make this project focusing on the medium we were each most experienced in. For example, one of my teammates wanted to make a documentary of sorts, as she was a visual communications major. The conflict in the group was frustrating and seemingly never ending, until we all realized that we were unable to truly make any headway into the project until we started making some crucial decisions. Sitting down together, we finally were able to think of a way to make everyone happy. We would make a blog style website where each of us could show our skills and focusing each webpage on a different aspect of the program.

Finally having a big goal in mind, we started making rapid progress. First, we made two individual video, one showcasing candid moments of the many students on the trip, the other

being a day-in-the-life style video to show viewers a first-person perspective, while also including interviews with our classmates to give an even deeper frame of reference. Next, we had a page with about four short blog style posts about different experiences popular with our classmates, as well as different references to Barcelonian culture. For example, one post talks about Cava, a sparkling wine that can only be made in Spain and is available in almost every restaurant you could set foot in. Finally, we had a section of the website dedicated to different statistics that our class made throughout our trip, for example, the total amount of croissants our class was able to eat as a collective throughout the month. This website gave us the creative freedom to put together our individual skills and create something incredible.

I believe there were two main points to this group led class. The first is the chance to explore Barcelona and its culture and share our findings, but the second was to force us to learn how to work together as a team. While in past group projects, there are times one can get away with doing no work, because the others will do it for them to save their own grade, our entire class was based on the group work. There was no chance for people to escape responsibility, or for one to take over and force everyone else to follow their lead, so conflict was inevitable. We were forced to find a solution if we wanted to pass, and we had to work together making this project for an entire month. This wasn't something you could put together in one night. I also want to put into consideration that, because we were in a different nation, the only people we knew were our classmates and teachers. You couldn't just give up and go home.

This project made me truly question if this trip was a good idea, or if I would be fit to work in similar environments in the future. I questioned if I was doing the right thing letting our most aggressive group member take the overall lead. I questioned if the project was ever going

to be finished since we were all working on unrelated characteristics of a website that wasn't made until the last week of our program. I questioned if playing peacekeeper was truly helping as it allowed one of my groupmates to try and take advantage and, rather than just ask for clarity, try and make me take on the research they oversaw through never-ending questions. I won't lie and say I wasn't brought to tears more than once throughout this process, but looking back I believe being a part of this program has shaped me more positively than any other experience I've had as a University of South Carolina student.

I learned to loosen the reigns and listen to our groupmate who wanted to lead but trust my gut and jump in with clear communication when I disagreed or found fault. I learned to quit stressing over my groupmate and, rather than answer every question and do the hard parts for them, explain how I can't hold their hand every step, but I will always be willing to help clarify or point them in the right direction. I learned how to use a program I had never used before to create a fun yet professional website to put together every piece each groupmate worked so hard on creating, and I have never been prouder of a group effort than I am of our website.

While in the past I enjoy working alone, this project has taught me that everyone brings something to the table. I would not have been able to create that entire website alone in the time I was a part of the study abroad program. I also believe that, looking back and seeing how I was able to find a way to work with that group and make such an amazing outcome, I know that I will be able to work with any group of people in the future. Working with a team gives you the opportunity to create things you couldn't alone, and after that experience I know not only the importance of teamwork, but also how to navigate it so that everyone's individual skills can shine through to make something amazing.